Harvard Health Systems Innovation Lab
2026 Hackathon Guide for Mentors

Thank you for joining us as a judge, and welcome to the 7th annual Health Systems Innovation Hackathon! The Health System Innovation Lab (HSIL) organizes a yearly Hackathon in collaboration with our collaborators around the world. The Hackathon is a transformative event with a clear mission: to empower innovators to develop innovative solutions that improve health systems. This dynamic and collaborative event brings together students, young professionals and experts from diverse fields to address critical health system challenges through innovation. By bringing together professionals from different backgrounds, it fosters cross-disciplinary collaboration and unconventional thinking to develop innovative solutions. Teams are supported to develop groundbreaking and practical solutions that can challenge the status quo and transform healthcare, bridging the gap between theory and practice. Teams will not only collaborate intensively during the event but hopefully also establish relationships and networks that extend beyond its duration.

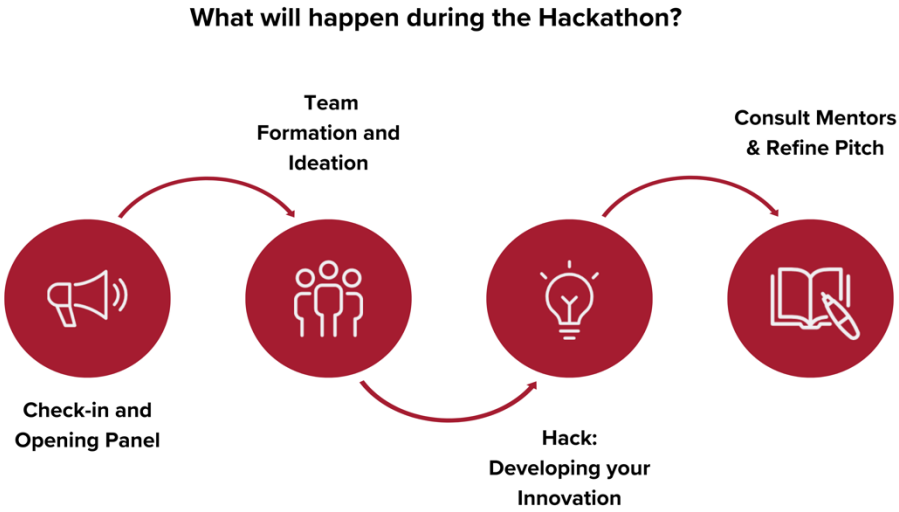
In summary, the HSIL Hackathon is a powerful platform for innovation and collaboration, dedicated to improving healthcare systems around the world.

The 2026 Hackathon

This year's Hackathon will take place on **Friday 10th and Saturday 11th April 2025** and the theme is: **'Building High-Value Health Systems: Leveraging Artificial Intelligence'**.

How is the Hackathon organized?

The Hackathon is organized as a **two-day in person event** in several Hubs across the world, including: North America, Central and South America, Europe, the UK, Asia and Africa. Over the two-day hackathon, teams will identify a health system challenge they want to tackle and develop an innovative solution to it. Teams will have access to mentors who have healthcare expertise and health innovation experience. They will advise the teams, challenge their assumptions, and provide feedback on their pitch. Teams will get ready to present their solution in front of a local judging panel by the end of the two days. Judges from each Hub will **select three winning teams.**



Mentoring

Each team will get support from local mentors in person in each Hub over the two-day event. The mentors have diverse skills and expertise to guide teams composed of students and young professionals from fields such as medicine, engineering, public health, and beyond. We have subject matter experts in healthcare offering clinical insights and understanding patient needs; healthcare technology specialists with experience in digital health and medical devices; professionals with backgrounds in engineering and artificial intelligence for technical guidance; public health and policy experts to navigate broader healthcare landscapes; design thinking and user experience specialists to prioritize user needs; entrepreneurs and business professionals to assist with business models and market analyses; effective communicators and presenters to help teams convey their ideas; and adaptable problem-solvers capable of addressing challenges and unforeseen issues.

What do we expect from mentors?

Local mentors will be available on-site to support teams through 1:1 team mentoring sessions. Online mentors are available during fixed time slots for 20-minute sessions per team. Teams can sign up for mentoring via the schedules provided through Slack.

Mentors will share their expertise in health, engineering, or business with teams by:

- Offering insights into critical challenges within health systems
- Advising teams on robust business models to ensure commercial viability
- Advising teams on how to refine and optimize their solution pitches

When teams are developing their ideas, mentors will press them on the following:

- What problem are you trying to solve?
- What is unique about the solution you are offering?
- What is currently done to solve this problem? who are the potential competitors?
- What is your unique differentiating factor?
- What are some of the limitations of your solution? How could you overcome them?

Guidelines

As a mentor, your goal is to provide helpful guidance to the teams:

- Keep an open mind – mentors should not drastically change the concept; instead, offer suggestions for improvement.
- Connect teams with other mentors who may have more relevant experience.
- Remind teams to focus on the realities of their target clinical setting since that should be the driving force behind the solutions they're developing.
- If you know of existing solutions that are similar to their idea, then share the relevant background information with the teams.
- Ask probing questions - help teams identify the riskiest assumptions associated with their ideas, and support them in testing those assumptions.
- Discuss sustainability and scalability: Talk about what it takes to commercialize a technology and scale it (e.g. payers vs. users, prototype development, clinical/field testing, regulatory challenges, manufacturing, sales/distribution partnerships.
- Help teams with their pitches: Encourage teams to craft concise, compelling messages and to tell a clear story with their pitch.

Team Blind Spots	How You Can Help (Guiding Questions)
• Entering with pre-existing solution • Trying to solve too much • Solving an already thoroughly solved problem • Ignoring the business model	• "What's the problem you're working on in one sentence?" • "Who are the users?" • Suggest focusing on one problem, one user, and one target market initially • Remind them to look for competitors - how would they differentiate themselves • "How would you make the idea sustainable?" • "Who are the customers, why might they pay for this?"

What to expect for the pitch?

At the end of the Hackathon, teams will deliver a 3-minute presentation, or "pitch," to present their idea to the judges and persuade them of its merits.

Considering most Hackathon pitches last 3 minutes, here's a rule of thumb for maximizing impact within that tight timeframe that we shared with participants.

- **Introduction (10 seconds):** Briefly introduce yourself and your team in a memorable way. Since people recall more easily how things start and finish, ensure your introduction makes a lasting impression as the judges deliberate.
- **Problem statement (20 seconds):** Clearly describe the problem you are addressing. Whose lives can be improved by your solution, and what tangible impact will it have?
- **Product (1 minute):** Explain the technical aspects of your idea. Provide enough detail to demonstrate your technical expertise and decision-making process, without overwhelming your audience with excessive information.
- **Demo (1 minute):** Support your product presentation with a live demo (if possible) or use visualization tools to mock up the design, functionality, and key features
- **Wrap-up (30 seconds):** Summarize the main points of your pitch and end with a strong closing statement.

How will teams participating in the Hackathon be judged?

All teams will pitch their innovation in front of local judges on the **2nd day of the Hackathon**. Each Hub will select local judges to take part in the **judging panel** on **April 11th** (the exact time will depend on the local schedule of each Hub). The judging panel will consist of three to five judges collectively bringing in clinical, technical, and business expertise.

The judging panel will identify the best digital health solutions with a high potential for transforming healthcare systems and improving care around the world. Judging criteria can be found in the table below.

What happens after the Hackathon? The HSIL Venture Incubation Program

The top team (first place) from each Hub will present their innovation to a Global Judging panel online in the weeks following the Hackathon. The winners from the second round of judging will participate in a Venture Incubation program hosted by the Harvard Health Systems Innovation Lab and its collaborators. This program will be held virtually shortly after the Hackathon.

Judging rubric for the Health Systems Innovation Hackathon

Criterion	Considerations	Score
1. Challenge	- Is a clear need articulated? - Does the team demonstrate understanding of the root causes of the problem? - Is this a significant problem to address in terms of size, disease burden, consequences or perception? - Does the team provide a convincing rationale as to why this needs to be addressed urgently?	/5
2. Technology & Innovation	- Offers new technology solution (better / faster / cheaper) - Provides convincing rationale for why this unique approach has the potential to work (if it doesn't exist already in any other form) - If the solution is focused on low resource settings, it addresses relevant technical issues (e.g., low-cost components, intermittent power supply, limited internet) - Does the team clearly describe what the innovation is, its components and how it will address the challenge? - Does the innovation possess transformative potential to improve outcomes at the health systems level? - Does the team consider design and user experience in its innovation?	/5
3. Implementation	- Beyond need, is there a demand for this solution? - Does the team address obstacles to implementation and outlines a plan to overcome them? (e.g., Logistics, supply chain, overstretched implementing organizations, cultural appropriateness, etc.) - Does the team outline a plan to develop the innovation and introduce it into the health system? - Is there a sustainable business model and value proposition? - Are critical stakeholders, the health system and the context adequately considered as part of the implementation strategy?	/5
4. Team	- Is the team equipped with the right skill mix and attitude to implement the proposed innovation?	/5
5. Pitch	- Does the team demonstrate the prototype or solution? - Does the team clearly articulate the challenge it is addressing and how their innovation is addressing it? - Does the team document next steps clearly – i.e. how they plan on working in the field to test their solution and how to continually incorporate end user feedback? - Are visual aids (presentation design and use of diagrams and figures) used effectively?	/5
6. Question & Answer	- Is the team able to successfully defend their position and confidently respond to specific questions from the judges?	/5
7. Total		**/30**